

Recovery roadmap for overcoming friendship trauma and rebuilding self-trust after abuse — Action Checklist

PRINT THIS PAGE AND KEEP IT SOMEWHERE VISIBLE

DOCUMENT THE ACTUAL ABUSE

- ☐ **Create a written Abuse Pattern Map by opening a blank document titled "What Actually Happened" where you inventory every specific pattern of harmful behavior that occurred.:** Create a written Abuse Pattern Map by opening a blank document titled "What Actually Happened" where you inventory every specific pattern of harmful behavior that occurred.
- ☐ **Build a detailed timeline with dates, events, and exact descriptions of what she did, replacing vague statements like "she criticized me" with specific examples like "she called my presentation embarrassing in front of three coworkers.":**
Build a detailed timeline with dates, events, and exact descriptions of what she did, replacing vague statements like "she criticized me" with specific examples like "she called my presentation embarrassing in front of three coworkers."
- ☐ **Identify all instances of manipulation and covert control, including whether she required your permission for decisions, used guilt to isolate you from other friends, or regularly reinterpreted your words incorrectly.:** Identify all instances of manipulation and covert control, including whether she required your permission for decisions, used guilt to isolate you from other friends, or regularly reinterpreted your words incorrectly.
- ☐ **Record specific incidents of social sabotage, documenting whether she positioned herself as the authority on what you were "really" like, turned mutual friends against you, or gathered information to use against you later.:**
Record specific incidents of social sabotage, documenting whether she positioned herself as the authority on what you were "really" like, turned mutual friends against you, or gathered information to use against you later.

SEPARATE TRUTH FROM FANTASY

- ☐ **Compare your written timeline against the friendship you replay in your head when you miss having someone to text at midnight, then write down where the two versions don't match.:** Compare your written timeline against the friendship you replay in your head when you miss having someone to text at midnight, then write down where the two versions don't match.
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- **Stop describing the abuse as "toxic" or "complicated" and replace those vague words with specific descriptions of the actual harmful behaviors you documented on your Abuse Pattern Map.:** Stop describing the abuse as "toxic" or "complicated" and replace those vague words with specific descriptions of the actual harmful behaviors you documented on your Abuse Pattern Map.

- **Accept that your symptoms are valid evidence, not exaggeration — panic attacks after the friendship ended, exhaustion that sleep doesn't fix, and second-guessing your memory are all normal responses to real abuse.:** Accept that your symptoms are valid evidence, not exaggeration — panic attacks after the friendship ended, exhaustion that sleep doesn't fix, and second-guessing your memory are all normal responses to real abuse.

- **Recognize that your prefrontal cortex overrode your nervous system's warnings by explaining away her behavior as stress or honesty, and reconnect with what your body was actually telling you during the friendship.:** Recognize that your prefrontal cortex overrode your nervous system's warnings by explaining away her behavior as stress or honesty, and reconnect with what your body was actually telling you during the friendship.

REBUILD JUDGMENT AND SELF-TRUST

- **Rebuild your self-trust by re-reading your Abuse Pattern Map and affirming aloud that what you documented was real and that you are not making up what happened to you.:** Rebuild your self-trust by re-reading your Abuse Pattern Map and affirming aloud that what you documented was real and that you are not making up what happened to you.

- **Create written boundary statements based on what you learned from the abuse map, naming specific behaviors you'll no longer tolerate in any future friendship such as guilt-tripping for other relationships.:** Create written boundary statements based on what you learned from the abuse map, naming specific behaviors you'll no longer tolerate in any future friendship such as guilt-tripping for other relationships.

- **Rebuild your internal trust by checking in with your body and emotions each day and noting when your nervous system signals something is wrong, even if you can't yet act on those signals.:** Rebuild your internal trust by checking in with your body and emotions each day and noting when your nervous system signals something is wrong, even if you can't yet act on those signals.

- **Begin entering new social spaces gradually, accepting that you may feel guarded or brace for the next thing, and reminding yourself that not every room contains a person who will hurt you.:** Begin entering new social spaces

gradually, accepting that you may feel guarded or brace for the next thing, and reminding yourself that not every room contains a person who will hurt you.

Companion to the full guide in your Lemon Squeezy library — check off each item as you complete it.